1648, the Nyaunggan dynasty experienced a slow and steady decline for the next 100 years. Instead of clarifying the issue of royal succession, administrative reforms diminished the power of the princes while strengthening the power of ministers. Burmese politics descended into princely-ministerial factions. A series of weak kings would continue to rule Burma until the mid-17th century until the overthrow of the last Toungoo monarch, Mahadhammaraja Dipiti (r. ca. 1733–1752).

By the mid-17th century, palace intrigues began undermining the authority of the king. Ministers and their patronage networks sought power and influence at the royal court. By the reign of Minye Kyawdin (r. ca. 1673–1698), the king no longer exercised any real political authority, as power had devolved and fragmented into the hands of ministers, with provincial officials allying themselves with one ministerial court faction or another in return for securing royal appointments. The usurpation of the crown diminished the state's authority. Taking advantage of weakened royal authority, provinces and vassal states slowly gained their independence from Ava. During the reign of King Tanin-ganwei (r. ca. 1714–1733), the kingdom of Lan Na (Chiang Mai) revolted and gained independence in 1725. In 1733, and again in 1735, armies from Manipuri led by Gharib Newaz invaded and plundered Burmese territory west of the Ayeyarwaddy.

The Mon revolts that began in 1740 challenged the power of the last monarch of Nyaunggan dynasty, eventually leading to its downfall. The Mon rebellion began in Pegu in 1740 when the Burman governor openly rebelled against the weak authority of Ava by proclaiming himself king of Pegu. Fed up with the continuing resource and taxation demands and unwilling to accept a Burmese king in Pegu, the Mon rebelled. Rioting ensued, and the pretender to the throne was murdered. The Ava king Mahadhammaraja Dipiti then installed his uncle as the new governor of Pegu. The installation of yet another Burman overlord triggered further rioting in Pegu in which the Mon went on to kill Burmese court officials. Mahadhammaraja Dipiti further exacerbated Mon-Burman tensions by ordering the massacre of the Mon in Pegu in retaliation for the killing of the court officials. The Gwe Shans used the conflict between the Mon and the Burmans to stage their own rebellion. With the aid and support of the Mon and Karen communities, the Shans were able to take Pegu in 1740. Following the conquest of Pegu, the Mon selected an ethnic Burman monk